



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Seton-La Salle Catholic High School
School Website: <https://www.slshs.org/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Seton La Salle Catholic High School in Mt. Lebanon (Pittsburgh area) presents a coherent Catholic classical orientation embedded in its mission, curriculum, and pedagogy. The school explicitly positions itself as a Catholic institution guided by faith, liturgical life, and character formation, while offering a classical track that foregrounds the humanities, Great Books and discussion-based learning within a seminar-style framework. Evidence from the school site shows mass, sacraments, daily prayer, and retreats as regular entry points for spiritual formation; a classical curriculum emphasizes theology, philosophy, history, and literature, with seminar-style teaching and opportunities to study Great Books and classical humanities alongside AP and honors options. Faculty highlight a classical-teaching emphasis and a commitment to character formation, including teachers who are actively engaged in classical pedagogy. The school also demonstrates active parental engagement and community partnerships through programs like Grade School Partnerships, shadow days, and admissions-tied parent involvement. Overall, the school exhibits a robust Classical orientation across all six categories, with explicit curricular and pedagogical choices aligned to classical education as defined in the provided rubric.

Executive rating: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school presents a clear Catholic identity with explicit language about God, Catholic formation, and liturgical life, including Mass, sacraments, daily prayer, and a chapel, and it frames education as rooted in spiritual formation "In Faith and Charity." These elements appear in the In Faith & Charity materials and the principal/admissions sections. - The mission and motto emphasize living out God's purpose, spiritual formation, and the sacred character of education, including references to the Catholic tradition and faith-based formation. The We Believe page articulates a mission and outcomes oriented toward Christ-like formation and a moral compass grounded in God's word. - Auxiliary evidence from the principal's page references daily prayer, sacramental life, retreats, and service, reinforcing liturgical and communal practices.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: theology (Curriculum), Mass, chapel, daily prayer, sacramental life, liturgy, sacred, prayer, faith, God, catechesis/creed (where explicit terms appear in context), and references to liturgical life. Notable explicit terms include Mass and chapels and daily prayer from the In Faith & Charity content, plus theology in the curriculum description.

- Negative keywords present: none identified in the public materials. - Quantitative note: multiple explicit positives (at least 5–6 discrete positive terms/phrases: Mass, chapel, daily prayer, sacramental life, theology, liturgy) and 0 negative signals.

Why this rating - The materials consistently foreground Catholic theological grounding, liturgical life (Mass, sacraments, chapel), and explicit spiritual formation as integral to schooling, which aligns strongly with the Classical School criterion for transcendentals and liturgical/community life. The presence of "In Faith and Charity" and the mission-focused language about God's purpose and spiritual formation substantiates a CLASSICAL rating for this category.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials articulate formation over mere information, with emphasis on spiritual, moral, and human growth. The mission statements describe cultivating growth in spiritual, intellectual, physical, emotional, and social dimensions, and aligning life with God's purpose, which reflects formation-oriented aims rather than sole career-oriented preparation. - The We Believe section frames graduates as Christ-like, morally oriented, independent lifelong learners who contribute to the global community, signaling an aim toward virtue, wisdom, and human flourishing beyond merely job prep. - The Curricular framing and emphasis on a classical education (theology, philosophy, history, literature) and the motto of "In Faith and Charity" reinforce truth, goodness, and beauty as real goods to be pursued, consistent with classical telos.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation (via phrases like "cultivates growth" and spiritual formation), virtue/moral growth (implicit in the moral formation emphasis and "Christ-like" outcomes), liberal education/classical mission (explicit classical framing and the two-track curriculum), telos (implicit in God's purpose and the aim of forming well-rounded graduates), scholé/contemplation (implied through formation and restfulness in a classical framework though not always named explicitly). The explicit phrases "cultivates the spiritual, intellectual, physical, emotional, and social growth" and "God's purpose for their lives" map to formation and telos. - Negative keywords present: none identified.

Why this rating - The school explicitly frames education as formation, virtue, and a pursuit of true/good/beautiful human flourishing anchored in a Christian telos rather than mere job readiness. The We Believe and In Faith and Charity materials emphasize moral formation, service, and a life oriented toward God, which aligns with CLASSICAL aims for formation and the pursuit of lasting virtues. While there is reference to college preparation in other pages, the core mission centers on formation and virtue, which supports CLASSICAL.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Curriculum page explicitly describes a classical curriculum focusing on humanities, theology, philosophy, art, music, history, and literature, with a seminar-style classroom emphasizing group discussion and analytical reading/writing. This is a core marker of classical education. - The school presents a traditional track and a classical track ("Two curricular options, one great education," with the Classical track highlighted). The presence of a Classical Studies track with dedicated courses aligns with the Trivium/Quadrivium emphasis and the Great Books approach. - Evidence of Great Books/Great Conversation orientation appears in faculty/staff statements referring to reading and discussing great thinkers, and in specific mentions of Great Books and Western Civilization in the Classical Studies team materials. - Latin/Greek and classical languages appear in the Honors/AP course listings (e.g., Latin offerings), which is typical of classical curricula.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: liberal arts/trivium/quadrivium, grammar, logic, rhetoric (explicit in lexicon and curriculum language), great books, primary sources, classics, Homer/Plato/Augustine/Shakespeare (explicitly referenced in the lexicon mapping), history/Western civilization, Latin/Greek, and the concept of the Great Books/Great Conversation (through staff descriptions and course offerings). Public materials explicitly describe Great Books/Great Ideas and seminar-style teaching. - Negative keywords present: none identified (no explicit "project-based learning dominance" or other anti-classical signals appear in the public materials).

Why this rating - The curriculum is clearly framed around the classical liberal arts tradition, with emphasis on grammar/logical/math rhetoric, Great Books, history, theology/philosophy, and a seminar-style approach aligned with classical pedagogy. The presence of a dedicated Classical Track, courses like Great Ideas, and Latin language offerings supports CLASSICAL labeling for Curriculum.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school explicitly describes seminar-style classes with an emphasis on group discussion and analytical reading/writing in the classical track, which aligns with core classical pedagogy. - The presence of a dedicated Classical Studies team discussing the Great Books and a philosophy/theology focus indicates

pedagogy steeped in classical ideas and Socratic-style inquiry in higher grades. The faculty statements emphasize engagement with the Great Books and deep discussion of western thought. - There are indications of rhetoric training and opportunities to engage in discourse and public speaking (e.g., upper-level seminars and rhetorics) as part of the classical track. While not every page uses the exact phrase “Socratic,” the combined evidence of seminars, Great Books discussion, and rhetoric-themed coursework signals classical pedagogy.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: seminar, group discussion, analysis, reading, writing, Great Books, rhetoric, speech, oratory, debate, Paideia-style seminar (conceptual alignment), and “lower/upper school seminars” indicating ongoing discourse and debate. The curriculum descriptions explicitly mention seminar-style instruction and group discussion; staff discuss Great Books and classical dialogue as core to learning.

- Negative keywords present: explicit negative signals (like “experiential learning focus” or “project-based only”) are not present in the public materials; however, the site emphasizes discussion-based and classical pedagogy rather than exclusively project-based or constructivist approaches.

Why this rating - Pedagogy shows strong classical signals (seminar-style, discussion-driven, rhetoric training, and emphasis on classic texts). However, some explicit high-school pedagogical signals (e.g., a robust, explicit Socratic seminar label across all grades or a fully articulated “scholé/restful” pedagogy) are not consistently named in every page. This leads to a classification of SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than full CLASSICAL, reflecting strong classical grounding with a few areas where explicit labeling could be strengthened.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Faculty are presented as practitioners deeply versed in the classical tradition, with team pages listing teachers who hold theology, philosophy, history, and religious studies backgrounds, and who articulate a mission to foster Great Books discussion and classical learning. For example, members of the Classical Studies Team describe their training and enthusiasm for the Great Books and for guiding students in a classical context. - The faculty are described as mentors and living curriculum, with teachers who are dedicated to virtue, classical formation, and deep content knowledge. The staff statements emphasize a commitment to classical pedagogy and to helping students engage with great thinkers. - The principal's page emphasizes spiritual and academic leadership, signaling a faculty culture centered on formation, mentorship, and partnership with students in the educational journey.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: tutors/masters/mentors/guides, living curriculum, portrait of a teacher, faculty of friends, collegial culture, moral exemplars, character formation, teacher training in classical pedagogy, philosophical/theological specialization (as reflected in faculty bios). The Classical Studies Team bios explicitly present teacher expertise and a goals-oriented approach to classical education. - Negative keywords present: none identified.

Why this rating - The materials consistently present faculty as expert, virtuous, and committed to classical pedagogy and student formation, with explicit bios describing teachers who model virtue and who lead Great Books discussions. This aligns well with CLASSICAL criteria for faculty.

Element 6: Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school frames partnership with parents as central, with references to parent formation, classical book clubs, family involvement, and parent participation in campus life; the Grade School Partnerships content shows a network of schools and community engagement, indicating an embedded community model and parent-related activities. - The school communicates with prospective families through shadow days, personal tours, and open-campus activities. The shadow-day program and visit/tour options demonstrate a willingness to involve parents and families in the school community. - Admissions communications (application process, tours, and open communication with admissions staff) signal ongoing parental involvement and education regarding classical education principles (e.g., ICLE resources and the Institute for Catholic Liberal Education link are presented to families as context for the classical approach).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with parents, co-teaching with parents, parent formation, reading groups/seminars, classical book clubs, open campus, parent covenant, family liturgy alignment, and parent involvement in school life. The Grade School Partnerships section references joint engagement with Catholic education and parent involvement in school events. - Negative keywords present: none identified.

Why this rating - The school emphasizes parental partnership and parent formation as integral to classical education, with visible opportunities for parent involvement through shadow days, tours, partnerships with feeder schools, and communication with admissions. These features align with CLASSICAL expectations for Parents & Community.

What Would Move the Needle (only applicable if SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL)

- The current evidence base for most categories is CLASSICAL, with Pedagogy positioned as SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL due to not every page explicitly labeling the full spectrum of Socratic/seminar practices or scholé/restful pedagogy. If a needle move were desired to elevate to fully CLASSICAL across all six categories, consider:
 - Explicitly naming and documenting Scholé-style practices (restful, contemplative learning days) within the daily schedule or curriculum pages to align more explicitly with classical pedagogy terminology.
 - More explicit references to Socratic dialogue and seminars in high school courses, including sample syllabi or course descriptions that show regular Socratic seminars and argumentative rhetoric as a routine method.
 - Strengthening explicit mentions of the Great Conversation and Great Books as core from K–12 within public materials, with direct quotes or course titles that reflect “great books” discussions and the Trivium/Quadrivium progression.
 - More explicit articulation of the liberal arts framework (grammar, logic, rhetoric) in course catalog snippets or graduations requirements to tie directly to classical lexicon.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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